CHAPTER FOUR:
SETTING THE STAGE

On a film like Iron Man 2, if the sets don't look real, the characters will fall flat. Fortunately, the team led by Production Designer Michael Riva was up to the task. "The fun in designing where I'm going to shoot," says Riva, "whether it's on location or a stage set, is really what you see in your mind. That first pass in the script, or even beat sheet in the case of these pictures, you get a sense of something. Usually, that first take you had is the one you end up with."

But the practical realities are never far from Riva's mind. "You also have to keep in mind production. My job first is to design the look of the picture; the budget is not my first concern. But a close second is the budget, because you can dream all you want—but if they're not going to give you the money, you're not going to be able to build it or use it."

Set decorator Lauri Gaffin is a crucial part of the team. Gaffin says that she and Riva have "worked together on over nine movies; we've had a great collaboration. He is always very enthusiastic and we do a lot of research together at the beginning of the movie. We do have an incredible shorthand and he gives me tremendous freedom and trusts me to go out in the world and bring back wonderful ideas and he's very open to that. He's open to everyone that way, and that's a really wonderful characteristic of his."

"Usually if it's right," says Riva, "the simplest solution is the best, the most unfussy is the best. You can feel it's right. If you're working too hard to make something work, you've got to change the whole thing.

"This is the number one prerequisite of a successful designer: It's like a puppet show. You're not supposed to see the strings. We're there to service the story, not to highlight what we can do. So, that's distracting. The worst thing you want is a set that's over-decorated, over-designed—unless it serves the story."



Jonathan Bach